

nel played high priest and family counsellor opening the dialogue for reconciliation between the newlyweds and the bride's parents. The belligerent couple held out for some time on the show, before the family accepted their condition that the newlyweds' parents should get together and welcome them back at a reception in Hyderabad.

The lovers' tryst couldn't have come at a worse time for Chiranjeevi who is under tremendous pressure to take a plunge into politics from his Kapu community—a force to reckon with in about 60 of the 294 assembly constituencies in Andhra Pradesh. For more than a decade, Kapu kinsmen

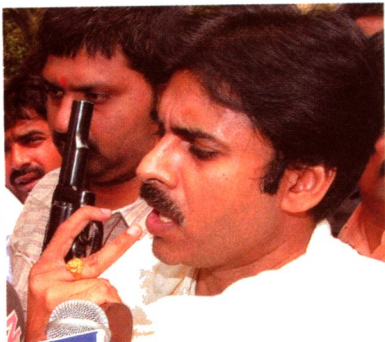
and film fans have been eager to see Chiranjeevi get on to the political stage. This idea sprang from the success of the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) founder N.T. Rama Rao who declared his intentions on turning 60 and rode to success in less than a year in the January 1983 elections. However, the emergence of TDP led to it increasingly becoming a cohort of the Kamma caste while the Congress was perceived as the party of the Reddys. And it is this caste domination of both major parties that has propelled some Kapu leaders to project Chiranjeevi not as a mere mascot for the clan but even as a potential chief minister.

What Andhraites are waiting to know now is whether the Telugu star will take the plunge. However, the actor himself is non-committal. There are several factors he has to take into account. First, his fan following is larger in Telangana than in the southern coastal districts—where the Kapu community forms a sizeable section of the population—with his films raking in much more in Telangana compared to the rest of the state. Second, his acting and movie plans, including the

finances, are managed by his brother-in-law Allu Aravind, the son of yesteryear Telugu film comedian Allu Ramalingaiah. Chiranjeevi had modest beginnings as the son of a government employee, which limits his appetite to take risks and makes him less decisive.

No less important is the fact that the loss of face, because of Srima's tantrums, has come at a time when Chiranjeevi is guiding his only son Ram Charan Teja to build a film career. The youngster's debut film, *Chiruta*, has done reasonably well at the box office though the response is not comparable to the appeal of Chiranjeevi's first hit release *Pranam Khareedu* way back in 1978.

At 52, Chiranjeevi still has several years of acting ahead of him. On the anvil are a few with his son, as the Bachchans have done in Bollywood, and he has even bigger plans for Teja. Just as thespians NTR and Akkineni Nageswara Rao groomed their sons Balakrishna and Nagarjuna earlier in Tollywood, Chiranjeevi is meticulously planning Teja's future. But, for the moment, it's Srima's story that's lighting up the small screens in Andhra Pradesh. ■



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